

MICHAEL · NEO PALAEOLOGUS

HIS GRAMMAR

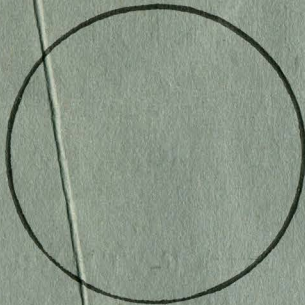
BY

HIS FATHER
STEPHEN N.
PALAEOLOGUS

A brilliantly original and thought-provoking treatise emphasising the philosophical rather than the philological aspect of grammar, fully illustrated with pictures and with excerpts from contemporary journalism; the book is a serious and at the same time an amusing and entertaining contribution to the science of language.

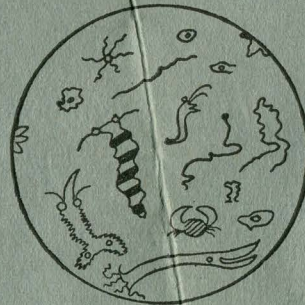
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PALÆOLOGICAL GRAMMAR



A representative sample of pure English as seen under the palæologigrammatical microscope. The student, after spending several years contemplating, analysing, parsing and reproducing this perfection of classic purity, matriculates with honours by means of answers to questions, both expressed in English that is as pure and undefiled as the representative sample.

NEO-PALÆOLOGICAL GRAMMAR



A representative sample of ordinary English as seen under the neo-palæologigrammatical microscope. The student, entranced by the whales, sharks, crabs and other palpable and glaring instances of that delightful genus *monstrum horrendum*, shouts, "Darn the whales. . . ." *Hoc ait*, and choosing a lance: "With this one I think I shall hit it," he cries, and straight into its mouth, *ad intima viscera mittit*.

[SPECIMEN PAGE]

A SHORT HISTORY OF THE RISE AND FALL OF THEM, GRAMMARIANS; AND OF THE ARRIVAL OF A NEW GRAMMAR.

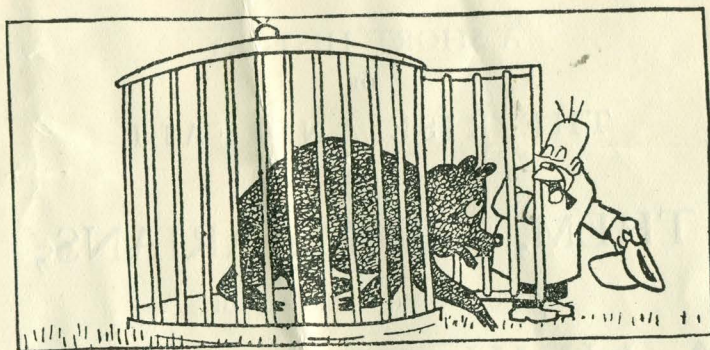
CHAPTER I. THE RISE

Who created them, Grammarians? God Almighty—and somehow they survived the Flood.

CHAPTER II. THE FALL

There was once upon a time a Great Beast whose name was General Public; and he was taught grammar by the wisest of all grammarians. And when the Beast came to years of discretion, the grammarian thought he would give him a treat and let him out for a run. Like this:—





With acknowledgements to the Artist, Mr. O. Jacobson

And there we can leave the grammarian. So much for the rise and fall. And now comes :—

CHAPTER III.

This chapter consists of a passage quoted (more or less accurately) from The Ninth Tale of the Tenth Decade of Slawkenbergius's Doctrine of Grammars (*Slawkenbergius, De Gram.*,) :

"'Tis a long journey, Sir," replied the master of the inn, "unless a man has great business." "Tut! Tut!" said the stranger, "I have been at the Promontory of Grammars; and have got me one of the goodliest and jolliest, thank Heaven! that ever fell to a single man's lot."

Whilst the stranger was giving this odd account of himself, the master of the inn and his wife kept both their eyes fixed full upon the stranger's Grammar. "By Saint Rada-gunda," said the innkeeper's wife to herself, "there is more in it than in any dozen of the largest grammars put together in all Strasburg! Is it not," said she, whispering her husband in his ear, "is it not a noble grammar?"

"'Tis an imposture, my dear," said the master of the inn; "'tis a false grammar."

"'Tis a true grammar," said his wife.

"'Tis diabolical," said he; "I smell the sulphur."

"There's life in it," said she.

"'Tis a dead grammar," replied the innkeeper.

"'Tis a live grammar; and if I am alive myself," said the innkeeper's wife, "I will read it."

"I have made a vow to St. Nicholas this day," said the stranger, "that my grammar shall not be read till—" Here the stranger, suspending his voice, looked up. "Till when?" said she hastily.

"It never shall be read," said he, clasping his hands and bringing them close to his breast, "till that hour—" "What hour?" cried the innkeeper's wife. "Never! never!" said the stranger, "never till I am got—" "For Heaven's sake! into what place?" said she. The stranger, *mulo consenzo*, rode away without saying a word.

MICHAEL NEO-PALÆOLOGUS HIS GRAMMAR

BY HIS FATHER

STEPHEN N. PALÆOLOGUS

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CONTENTS

PREFACE

INTRODUCTION

PART I.—SPADES

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN WE THINK?

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1. THE WHOLE OF A PART OF THE WHOLE | 7. ONCE UPON A TIME |
| 2. QUITE SO | 8. OVER THE GARDEN WALL |
| 3. NOT A BIT OF IT! | 9. IF IFS AND ANSWERE POTS AND PANS |
| 4. AND SO, OF COURSE | 10. THE PHANTOMS |
| 5. THE RANKINDICATIVE CASE | J. SAUCE |
| 6. AND WHERE DO I COME IN? | Q. TRY, TRY, TRY—WHAT! AGAIN? |
| | K. YOU NEEDN'T BELIEVE IT |

PART II.—HEARTS

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN WE SAY WHAT WE THINK?

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|
| 10. PARTING WITH THE WHOLE OF A PART OF THE WHOLE | 5. THE SINGULAR SOUL OF A PLURAL BODY |
| 9. OUT OF THE FRYING PAN INTO ... | 4. THE NEESINGS OF LEVIATHAN |
| 8. O WHAT A SURPRISE! | 3. I & Co. LTD. |
| 7. MIND THE HOOK! | 2. ALLANTOPOLEOSOPHY |
| 6. WHY "INVERTED" "COMMAS"? | 1. AND HE SAID, "— — —" |

QUEEN OF SPADES

Now, if I'm fond of you and you're fond of me, I don't expect you to say yes, quite so, exactly, yah, amen, or pop off.¹ I expect you to say something like, "But, my dear Sir, . . ."² On the other hand, I don't want you to get any further than that; I shall be quite content if I can see your lips coming together for the B. I, like most other *homines verisapientes* (what is the fun of having a watch if it doesn't keep better time than yours, or of knowing the truth if the other fellow does too?), being made as I am, I like to do most of the talking myself. And I have inherited from a long line of ancestors with the same tendency to annex, preserve and govern my own direct object, a very cunning way of getting all the words on my side, as mathematicians put as much as possible on one side of an equation, so that the whole business may, as far as the other side is concerned, be said to be equal to nothing.³ And this is how it is done.

First of all let me point out that most of us feel diffident about saying a plain "no" to what is obviously true. If I say the sun's shining, you may want to say no, and yet not like to put it as bluntly as that; so you say, "I know, but . . ." which means, "What you say doesn't count, and what I was going to say is . . ." Now I, being the penultimate fruit (some day, Michael, I hope you'll promote me to antepenultimation) of a long line of acute and cunning ancestors, I can foresee your little game. And I take what you were going to say and put it on my side with a minus sign in front. So that instead of getting the following conversation: I: "The sun's shining." U: "I know, but it's very cold," where there is a highly undesirable division of labour I arrange it so—I: "Though it's very cold, the sun's shining." U: "O!" And I can assure you that, with some people (with you,

¹"Dennis lived on unanswered and therefore little read: Addison knew the policy of literature too well to make his enemy important by drawing the attention of the public upon a criticism which though sometimes intemperate was often irrefragable."

²"Now if I might presume," said the Corporal, "to differ from your Honour . . ."

"Why else do I talk to thee, Trim?" said my uncle Toby, mildly.

I cannot remember when or where, but I believe Mr. James Agate once went so far as to write (probably in *Alarums and Excursions*): "I cannot imagine a more honourable career than to knock out and be knocked out."

³"Unto me men gave ear, and waited, and kept silence at my counsel. After my words they spake not again; and my speech dropped upon them" (Job xxix. 21-22). Oh! the sweet bitterness of looking back upon a perfect past! For he has just said: "Oh, that I were as in the days when God preserved me!" *Adolescens hic sine controversia disertus est.*

[SPECIMEN PAGE]



This very whimsical book will certainly be enjoyed by all who are adequately endowed with a sense of humour. But there is also a very serious reason for the author's quarrel with grammar 'as she is taught.' He is convinced that its educational value in training the intelligence is largely destroyed by the excessive emphasis laid on the 'parsing' of words, to the exclusion of their meaning, and insists with abundant illustration that their actual meaning can, in most cases, only be ascertained from a knowledge of their context. In regarding the neglect of context as the capital offence of traditional grammar, he agrees, as a grammarian, with the modern logicians who bring the same charge against the traditional logic.

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